

TOPIC 5: FELLOWSHIP IN THE EARLY CHURCH (PART 2)

1. Fraud in the Church – Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:1–11)

Ananias and his wife Sapphira sold a piece of property but kept back part of the proceeds while pretending to give the whole amount. Peter confronted Ananias for lying to the Holy Spirit; Ananias fell down and died. Later Sapphira repeated the lie and also died. Great fear came upon the whole church. The issue was not the amount kept but the deception – lying to God while seeking a reputation for generosity.

2. Murmuring and Complaints (Acts 6:1–2)

As the number of disciples grew, a complaint arose from the Hellenists (Greek-speaking Jews) against the Hebrews because their widows were being neglected in the daily distribution. The apostles recognised the problem and sought a solution so that they could continue to focus on prayer and the ministry of the word.

3. Lessons

- Honesty before God is essential; hypocrisy is serious.
- The Church must address real needs and complaints fairly.
- Leaders should prioritise prayer and the word while ensuring practical care is organised.

4. Summary

Ananias and Sapphira warn against deceit in the community of faith. The complaint about the widows shows that growth brings practical challenges that must be handled with justice and wisdom.

End of Topic 5